Introduction to Philosophy
Philosophy 101

Spring 2026
Tu Th 11:30-12:45, Room W706
Office hours: Tu 1:00 – 2:00, Room W1448

Instructor: Boris Ayala
boris.ayala@hunter.cuny.edu

What is real? How can we know? How should we live? In this course, we will explore how some great minds have approached questions like these. We will do it not because they got the right answers, but because they offer wonderful examples of excellent reasoning and argumentation. My goal is to help you develop two skills that will be useful to you wherever life takes you: how to think carefully and argue clearly.

Required Readings
You don't need to buy any textbooks. I will post on Brightspace the required readings. Please print them, read them in advance, and bring them to the relevant class. We will often do close reading in class, and to follow you will need to have the text before you.

Class Philosophy
Since thinking and writing are both skills, we can improve them with practice. Accordingly, this course is set up to encourage practice. Every class, we will analyze and sketch out the arguments in the assigned reading, and we will also think about the many ways one could respond. Then, four times during the semester, we will write our own arguments in class.

Grade Components

3 Arguments	45 points
Participation	15 points
Quizzes	20 points
Final Argument	20 points
Total	100 points

Grade Scale

97 – 100	A+	78 – 80	B-
92 – 96	A	75 – 77	C+
89 – 91	A-	70 – 74	C
85 – 88	B+	60 – 69	D
81 – 84	B	Less than 60	F

Arguments
There will be four in-class argument-writing assignments, one of them scheduled during what would be the final exam. (There is no final exam for this class.) Each assignment will have two components: an outline and the argument proper. You should spend at least 15 minutes on the outline, thinking about how to structure

your argument and laying it out. Once you've done that, write the structure out clearly on a new page, and only then proceed to write the actual argument. The outline will be worth five points each time, and the argument will be worth 10 points the first three times, and 15 points the last time. If for any reason you cannot make it to class on an argument day, let me know *in advance* so we can make alternative arrangements. The make-up must be taken within a week of argument day.

Quizzes
We will have 23 days of regular classes during the semester. On 15 of those days, class will start with a quick quiz on the reading assigned for that day. Each quiz is worth 2 points, and I will only count your 10 best quizzes. If you take all 15 quizzes, you will get two additional points on your final grade.

Participation and Attendance
Everybody will begin the semester with 5 points. You can earn up to 10 more by asking questions or volunteering answers. You may also lose points, however, if you check your cell phone, chat with other students during class, or engage in otherwise uncool behavior. If you don't participate in class, you will keep the original 5 points.

I will take attendance at the beginning of each class and expect you to be here on time. If you arrive after I take attendance, you will be considered absent. You may still earn participation points on any day you happen to arrive late.

The first three unexcused instances of lateness or absence are free. After that, I will take off one participation point per absence/lateness. However, if you reach 10 late or absent days in a semester, you will have failed this course.

Electronics Policy
The use of any electronics in class is prohibited.

Academic Integrity
Any instances of cheating will result in your failing this course. The CUNY Policy on Academic Integrity applies to this course, and further consequences may follow.

ADA Policy
Students with documented disabilities (including Emotional, Medical, Physical, and/or Learning disabilities) are encouraged to consult the Office of AccessABILITY, located in Room E1214B, to secure necessary academic accommodations.

Schedule for the Semester

1	Jan 27 Welcome!	Jan 29 NO CLASS
2	Feb 3 Russell 1	Feb 5 Descartes
3	Feb 10 Russell 2	Feb 12 NO CLASS
4	Feb 17 NO CLASS	Feb 19 Hume
5	Feb 24 Berkeley	Feb 26 Moore
6	Mar 3 ARGUMENT DAY	Mar 5 Plato
7	Mar 10 Gettier	Mar 12 Searle
8	Mar 17 Kripke	Mar 19 Nagel
9	Mar 24 ARGUMENT DAY	Mar 26 Descartes and Elisabeth
10	Mar 31 Smart	Apr 2 SPRING BREAK
11	Apr 7 SPRING BREAK	Apr 9 SPRING BREAK
12	Apr 14 Locke	Apr 16 Williams
13	Apr 21 Ayer	Apr 23 Strawson
14	Apr 28 ARGUMENT DAY	Apr 30 Singer
15	May 5 Arpaly	May 7 Diamond
16	May 12 E. Harman	May 14 Street
17	May 19 McGrath	May 21 FINAL EXAM